

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, morning sun, becoming cloudy, high 52. Tonight, breezy early, occasional rain and drizzle, low 43. Tomorrow, partly sunny, high 60. Weather map, Page A24.

VOL. CLXXV No. 60,829

© 2026 The New York Times Company

FRIDAY, MARCH 20, 2026

Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



In Arizona, near Mexico. U.S. border controls are designed primarily to stop inbound threats rather than to monitor outbound traffic. PHOTOGRAPHS BY PAUL RATJE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Secret Flow of Guns From U.S. Shops to Mexico’s Violent Cartels

By PAULINA VILLEGAS

PHOENIX — The 17-year-old sat in a hotel room, running a high-stakes logistics hub from his smartphone. He scrolled through listings of weapons for sale on WhatsApp and fielded requests like a call-center operator, dispatching orders in real time: Kalashnikovs, AR-15-style rifles and lots of ammunition.

The pace of business has become relentless, said the arms smuggler, the Arizona-born son of a local cartel cell leader. Though still in high school here in Phoenix, he is now handling as many as 200 firearms orders a week, roughly double what he shipped to Mexico before President Trump returned to the White House and pressed for a crack-down on the cartels.

Moving the weapons into Mexico is easy, he said, despite increased surveillance and enforcement on both sides of the border.



Guns smuggled to the Sinaloa Cartel, a major fentanyl trafficker.

“No one stops you unless you run a red light,” he said.

As the Trump administration pushes the Mexican government to do more against drug cartels, an unintended beneficiary has

emerged from the U.S. pressure campaign: the weapons smugglers who supply guns to the Sinaloa Cartel, the criminal powerhouse behind much of the fentanyl flooding American streets.

Mexican and U.S. authorities have poured billions of dollars into stemming the flow of drugs, particularly fentanyl going north. Yet gun traffickers have quietly moved what they say is an unprecedented amount of weapons south, arming the very criminal group the U.S.-Mexico effort was meant to weaken.

Over the past year and a half, the demand for weapons has exploded as the Sinaloa Cartel wages a three-front war: confronting an intensified offensive by the Mexican government, battling rival factions within its own ranks and stocking up for the prospect of U.S. military intervention.

I spent weeks interviewing seven cartel operatives directly involved in buying and delivering firearms from the United States. They are all tied to the Sinaloa Cartel, one of the world’s most powerful criminal groups. Two of

Continued on Page A6

Driver Killed 4. At Age 80, Is Probation Just?

By HEATHER KNIGHT

SAN FRANCISCO — It was a sunny Saturday in the West Portal neighborhood of San Francisco. The public library was bustling, and so were the cafes and ice cream shops.

Just outside the library, a mother, a father and their two little boys waited for a bus ride to the San Francisco Zoo. A perfect way, the couple figured, to celebrate their fourth wedding anniversary.

Then, at 12:12 p.m. on March 16, 2024, a boom shook the neighborhood, and the horror that followed still reverberates in San Francisco today.

A white Mercedes S.U.V. had traveled at highway speeds before it jumped the sidewalk, sheared a street pole, smashed a bolted-down garbage can and obliterated the bus stop. It finally came to a halt when it crashed into a fire hydrant.

The father, Diego Cardoso de Oliveira, was flung into the air and landed more than 100 feet away, witnesses estimated. The mother, Matilde Ramos Pinto, was trapped in the wreckage, fading in and out of consciousness.

Nearby, her baby cried.

“I was talking to the lady and making sure she stayed awake,”

Continued on Page A17



ROBYN BECK/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE — GETTY IMAGES

“We’re just seen as sex objects,” said Dolores Huerta, who co-founded U.F.W. with Cesar Chavez.

Union Pioneer Recalls Misogyny and Her Rape

By SARAH HURTES and MANNY FERNANDEZ

BAKERSFIELD, Calif. — In the days after Thanksgiving in 1986, Dolores Huerta was ready to celebrate. As one of the co-leaders of the United Farm Workers union, she had spent four months in Washington lobbying lawmakers to pass the Immigration Reform and Control Act, landmark legisla-

tion that granted amnesty to millions of undocumented immigrants.

A news conference was scheduled to celebrate the victory, but Ms. Huerta said she was not made aware of the event. Instead, she said, her fellow U.F.W. leader, Cesar Chavez, told her there was a crisis in Florida that required her immediate attention. Ms. Huerta flew to Florida, only to realize that

the emergency was nonexistent and no one was expecting her. She spent the next few days speaking at senior centers.

“I realized afterward they just wanted to get me out of the way so

Continued on Page A16

REACTION California lawmakers plan to rename Cesar Chavez Day as Farmworkers Day. PAGE A16

Attacks on Energy Sites Intensify a Global Crisis, Raising Pressure on U.S.

Trump Tries to Calm Fears on Oil Prices

This article is by **Tony Romm, David E. Sanger and Michael Levenson.**

WASHINGTON — The White House raced to find ways to reassure Americans as oil prices seesawed again on Thursday after a series of Iranian strikes on oil and gas facilities deepened a global energy crisis nearly three weeks into the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran.

President Trump, speaking during an Oval Office meeting with the Japanese prime minister, Sanae Takaichi, said that he would do whatever was necessary to ease the crisis but that it was temporary.

“I thought there was a chance it could be much worse,” he said. “It’s not bad. And it’s going to be over with pretty soon.”

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel said at a news conference on Thursday that the war could end “a lot faster than people think,” though he did not offer a concrete timeline. He said that Iran no longer has the ability to enrich uranium or manufacture ballistic missiles, but “there’s still more work to do, and we’re going to do it.”

He spoke after Iran hit oil and gas facilities in Israel, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates on Wednesday and Thursday, in retaliation for an Israeli strike on the South Pars natural gas field, a vast gas reservoir in the Persian Gulf that supplies Iran with much of the energy for

its businesses and homes.

The strikes further rattled global energy markets, which have already been shaken by Iran’s effective blockade of most Western oil shipments in the Strait of Hormuz, a conduit for about one-fifth of the world’s oil.

Oil prices have been surging since the start of the conflict on Feb. 28, with international crude futures up close to 50 percent in less than three weeks. As crude rises, so do gasoline, diesel and jet fuel, driving up the prices of everyday goods.

On Thursday, the average price of a gallon of gas in the United States hit \$3.88, up from \$2.93 a month ago. Mortgage rates also jumped this week, the third increase in a row, as high oil and gas prices weighed on housing costs for Americans.

Continued on Page A10



DOUG MILLS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

The president said the crisis would be over “pretty soon.”

Eliminating Iran’s Nuclear Fuel Is Much Easier Said Than Done

By DAVID E. SANGER

WASHINGTON — Repeatedly this week, President Trump has returned to his central argument for his decision to attack Iran, and to do it at this moment in history. Tehran was on the verge of getting a nuclear weapon, the president insists, and would use it first on Israel, then on the United States.

“They would use it within one hour or one day,” Mr. Trump said on Monday.

In fact, to listen to Mr. Trump in recent days is to hear a president debating whether to order the biggest Iran mission of all: to seize or destroy the near-bomb-grade nuclear material believed to be largely stored deep under a mountain in Isfahan.

It would, by any measure, be one of the boldest and riskiest military operations in modern Ameri-

can history, far more complex and dangerous than the effort to kill Osama bin Laden in 2011, or seize Nicolás Maduro from his bed in early January.

No one can be certain where all the fuel is. But in testimony before the House Intelligence Committee on Thursday, Tulsi Gabbard, the director of national intelligence, said the United States has “high confidence” it knows where the fuel, enriched to 60 percent purity, is stored. Rafael Grossi, the director general of the International Atomic Energy Agency, said on Wednesday in Washington that he believes it is “mainly in Isfahan,” where he last saw it during an agency inspection of the facility. “Some amount is in Natanz,” he

Continued on Page A10

Company Knew of Problems With Its Pacemaker Batteries

By KATIE THOMAS

Gladys Knepper, at 93, had a morning routine that never wavered. She woke up at six and made her bed. She got a pot of coffee going and went outside to pick up her copy of the Dubuque Telegraph Herald.

So when a neighbor in Dyersville, Iowa, noticed that Ms. Knepper’s newspaper was still on her doorstep on Mother’s Day in 2024, she knew something was wrong. Inside, she found Ms. Knepper sprawled on the floor.

It was the first in a series of blackouts that doctors initially attributed to the inevitable deterioration of an older woman. Ten days after her fall, they discovered the real problem: her pacemaker. She underwent surgery to

get a new one but by then, her heart was severely damaged. She died three weeks later.

Boston Scientific, the company that made the device, would later conclude that the battery inside it had failed. Two years earlier, a person in Finland had died as a result of the same malfunction. And for years, factory tests had revealed pacemaker batteries that were failing unexpectedly, according to internal company records and government inspection documents obtained by The New York Times.

Boston Scientific issued a recall for that device, its Accolade model, in December 2024, six months after Ms. Knepper’s death. The

Continued on Page A18



WEEKEND ARTS C1-12

Downtown, a Reopening

“New Humans: Memories of the Future” is the New Museum’s first show after a two-year expansion. PAGE C1

Sell Your Soul, if You Dare

The horror-comedy sequel “Ready or Not 2: Here I Come” makes a gruesome mockery of the ultrawealthy. PAGE C1

INTERNATIONAL A4-11

Trump’s Pearl Harbor Joke

Breaking a taboo, President Trump needed Japan’s prime minister about the World War II attack, and she appeared to take a deep breath. PAGE A9

Hungary Vote Focus: Ukraine

Prime Minister Viktor Orban is blocking a €90 billion loan to Kyiv, using it as election leverage. PAGE A8

OBITUARIES B11-12

Wrote About ‘the Baby Blues’

Paula Doress-Worters, an author of the 1970 women’s health encyclopedia “Our Bodies, Ourselves,” was 87. PAGE B12



NATIONAL A12-21

Summery Winter in California

A heat wave is pushing temperatures in San Francisco into the 80s, and into the high 90s in Los Angeles. PAGE A14

A Victim Reclaims Her Life

An artist was shoved into a passing subway car three years ago. Six surgeries later, she’s drawing again. PAGE A12

SPORTS B7-10

Consistent Connecticut

The Huskies sailed through the regular season without a strong challenge. Is there a team in the N.C.A.A. women’s tournament that could stun Geno Auriemma’s squad? PAGE B7

Repositioning Second Base?

With a focus on speeding up the game and encouraging more stolen bases, Major League Baseball will use the minor leagues as a testing lab for a host of rule change experiments. PAGE B10

OPINION A22-23

The Editorial Board

PAGE A22



BUSINESS B1-6

Farewell to the Metaverse

Meta announced changes that effectively leave Mark Zuckerberg’s vision of an immersive digital world based in virtual reality on life support. PAGE B1

